

Berkeley Neighbors for Housing & Climate Action 2024 Candidate Questionnaire

Candidate Name: Brent Blackaby

District / Office being sought: Berkeley City Council, District 6

1. Berkeley's Housing Element lays out the city's plan for new housing construction through 2031, ensuring the city can meet its Regional Housing Needs Allocation (RHNA) of ~9,000 homes across a range of income levels.

The Housing Element commits Berkeley to a number of major policy changes in order to meet state requirements for affirmatively furthering fair housing, including citywide zoning for "missing middle" housing, a San Pablo Specific Plan, an updated Demolition Ordinance, and upzoning along North Shattuck, Solano, and College Ave, among other items.

What is your view on the Housing Element and these policies? What are the most important things we need to do to implement the City's Housing Element?

Please discuss your ideas and priorities around:

- a. Missing Middle housing
- b. San Pablo specific plan
- c. Zoning for housing in high-resource neighborhoods like North Shattuck, Solano, and College Ave

I support Berkeley's Housing Element and its commitment to meeting RHNA goals through policies that promote equitable and sustainable growth. However, we must also be mindful of constraints in high fire hazard zones when adding density. Key priorities include:

- **Missing Middle Housing:** *Expanding zoning for missing middle housing is crucial. Allowing duplexes, triplexes, and fourplexes in traditionally single-family neighborhoods will increase housing supply and affordability without compromising neighborhood character. This helps diversify housing options while fostering inclusivity, but density in high fire hazard areas must be carefully considered. Planning Director Jordan Klein estimates that this will create at most ~1700 units over 8 years, more likely in the several-hundred range, so it is part of the solution – but far from the whole solution.*
- **San Pablo Specific Plan:** *I support the San Pablo Specific Plan, which encourages higher-density, transit-oriented development along a major corridor. Focusing on mixed-use developments near transit reduces car dependency, lowers emissions, and addresses both market-rate and affordable housing needs.*
- **Zoning for High-Resource Neighborhoods:** *Upzoning in high-resource areas like North Shattuck, Solano, and College Ave is essential for affirmatively furthering fair*

housing. While these areas offer access to schools, transit, and amenities, we must avoid adding density in high fire risk zones. The design review process is also essential to help gather feedback and ensure new development blends into the aesthetic of the existing neighborhood.

To implement the Housing Element, we need to streamline permitting, incentivize affordable housing, and engage the community while balancing safety in fire-prone areas.

2. Berkeley's Climate Action Plan sets forth a goal of 80% reduction in greenhouse gas (GHG) emissions by 2050. Today, the two major sources of GHG emissions in Berkeley are from gas-powered automobiles and natural gas used in buildings.

Berkeley has a variety of plans and programs intended to help address these emissions, including the Electric Mobility Roadmap and the Berkeley Existing Building Electrification Strategy. Other related efforts include the Bicycle Plan and Pedestrian Master Plan, as well as the City's now-defunct natural gas ban on new buildings. Upcoming policy initiatives include the Berkeley Building Electrification and Just Transition Pilot Program, Measure GG, the Bay Area Air Quality Management District's regional ban on new NOx-emitting appliances, and more.

What is your view on the Climate Action Plan and these strategies? What are the most important things we need to do to address greenhouse gas emissions?

Please discuss your ideas and priorities around how Berkeley can reduce emissions from transportation and buildings, and how we should align the climate transition with our other goals as a city.

I fully support Berkeley's Climate Action Plan and the goal of reducing greenhouse gas (GHG) emissions by 80% by 2050. To meet this ambitious target, we must focus on reducing emissions from two major sources: gas-powered vehicles and natural gas in buildings. Key strategies include:

- **Transportation Emissions Reduction:** *The Electric Mobility Roadmap, Bicycle Plan, and Pedestrian Master Plan are critical to shifting Berkeley towards sustainable transportation. I support expanding electric vehicle (EV) infrastructure, promoting EV incentives, and enhancing public transit. Additionally, increasing pedestrian and bicycle infrastructure will reduce car dependency, lower emissions, and improve public health. Prioritizing transit-oriented development will further encourage sustainable transportation and reduce traffic congestion.*
- **Building Electrification:** *The Berkeley Existing Building Electrification Strategy and the proposed Berkeley Building Electrification and Just Transition Pilot Program are essential for phasing out natural gas in buildings. Electrifying existing buildings, especially affordable housing, while ensuring equity through financial assistance for low-*

income households, will significantly reduce emissions. I also support the Bay Area Air Quality Management District's ban on new NOx-emitting appliances, which aligns with our goals for clean energy and air quality improvement.

- o I do not support Measure GG because it's a dramatic, unsustainable tax that does too much too fast. It hurts non-profits, small businesses (including local institutions like Berkeley Bowl and Boichik Bagels), healthcare providers (like Alta Bates), and at-risk renters. We must thoughtfully transition away from natural gas, in a way that brings the community along together, and not dramatically impose a sudden tax like Measure GG.*

As we pursue these climate goals, we must ensure the transition is equitable, especially for low-income and vulnerable communities. Programs like the Just Transition Pilot are critical to providing financial support and job training for workers affected by this transition. By aligning our climate efforts with housing affordability and social equity, we can create a sustainable, inclusive, and resilient future for Berkeley.

3. In your opinion, what was the most important City Council vote on Berkeley's housing crisis in the past four years? Briefly describe the issue, what you think of the Council's decision, and what you would have done had you been on the Council. For incumbents, please describe why you voted the way you did, and what you think now about that vote.

The Berkeley City Council's unanimous vote to eliminate single-family zoning in 2021 is a landmark decision addressing the city's housing crisis. I believe it was the Council's most important vote on housing in the past 4 years. Historically, single-family zoning in Berkeley contributed to racial and economic segregation, limiting housing supply and affordability. By allowing multi-unit buildings in traditionally single-family neighborhoods, the Council aimed to increase housing options, promote inclusivity, and meet the growing demand for affordable housing.

I support the Council's decision as a necessary step towards addressing housing inequity and expanding access to diverse housing types. Allowing duplexes, triplexes, and fourplexes in more neighborhoods will help Berkeley meet its housing goals, especially for middle-income families. However, we must remain mindful of safety concerns, such as avoiding increased density in high fire-hazard zones.

If I had been on the Council, I would have proudly voted for this zoning change. Berkeley's move away from exclusionary zoning is a crucial part of building a more equitable city and tackling our housing crisis head-on.

4. In your opinion, what was the most important climate or environmental issue faced by the Berkeley City Council in the last four years? Briefly describe the issue, what you think of the Council's decision, and what you would have done had you been on the Council. For incumbents, please describe why you voted the way you did, and what you think now about that vote.

The most important climate issue faced by the Berkeley City Council in the last four years has been the effort to transition away from fossil fuels and electrify buildings. This includes the groundbreaking ordinance that made Berkeley the first U.S. city to ban natural gas infrastructure in new buildings (which technically passed 5 years ago, but the legal battle has been raging for the past 4 years). The decision aimed to reduce greenhouse gas emissions and push for building electrification, aligning with Berkeley's Climate Action Plan goal of an 80% reduction in emissions by 2050.

The gas ban was a key part of Berkeley's larger environmental agenda, which also included initiatives like the Berkeley Existing Building Electrification Strategy and the upcoming Berkeley Building Electrification and Just Transition Pilot Program. These efforts faced legal challenges, particularly after a 2023 federal court ruling that overturned the natural gas ban on new buildings, creating a major setback for the city's climate goals.

I support the City Council's action, and would have joined my colleagues in a unanimous vote for the legislation. In addition, I would have continued to push for innovative policies like these, ensuring they align with our broader climate resilience goals while advocating for state and federal support to protect these initiatives from legal pushback.

5. To achieve its RHNA goals, Berkeley must continue to build homes for all income levels. These new residents will need to travel within Berkeley. Greenhouse gas (GHG) emissions from transportation comprise roughly 60% of total emissions in Berkeley.

How would you ensure that Berkeley continues to reduce GHG emissions while adding new homes?

To meet its Regional Housing Needs Allocation (RHNA) goals while reducing greenhouse gas (GHG) emissions, Berkeley must adopt a multi-faceted approach that focuses on sustainable, transit-oriented development. Here's how I would ensure that Berkeley continues to reduce transportation emissions while adding new homes:

- **Transit-Oriented Development (TOD):** Prioritize building new housing near BART stations, bus routes, and other major transit hubs. This strategy reduces car dependency, encourages the use of public transit, and promotes walking and biking. Expanding affordable housing options near transit also ensures equitable access to sustainable transportation.

- **Bicycle and Pedestrian Infrastructure:** Continue improving Berkeley's bike lanes and pedestrian pathways, making it safer and more convenient for residents to choose biking or walking over driving. The city's Bicycle Plan and Pedestrian Master Plan are critical components in reducing transportation-related GHG emissions.
- **Electric Vehicle (EV) Adoption:** Expand the city's EV charging infrastructure and promote incentives for electric vehicle adoption. This aligns with Berkeley's **Electric Mobility Roadmap** and helps transition away from gas-powered vehicles, a major source of emissions.
- **Green Building Practices:** Ensure that new housing developments incorporate energy-efficient designs, building electrification, and renewable energy sources, which help reduce overall emissions and align with the city's climate goals.

By focusing on sustainable development, active transportation, and electrification, we can build the housing Berkeley needs while ensuring a greener, more sustainable future for all residents.

6. Walking and biking presents opportunities to help Berkeley residents reduce their GHG emissions, but safety concerns can be a major deterrent. Of the two competing street paving measures on the ballot this November, one of the major differences between the two is the approach to funding safety improvements for walking and biking.

Measure EE would provide safety funding only for traffic calming on bicycle boulevards and major pedestrian projects identified in the Pedestrian Plan. Measure FF would provide funding to implement safety measures throughout the city, based on existing plans.

What is your perspective on how we should address pedestrian and cyclist safety on our streets? What is your perspective on these two measures?

Increasing safety for everyone that uses our streets & transportation infrastructure – transit riders, pedestrians, bicyclists, and drivers -- is essential to reaching our Vision Zero goals and reducing greenhouse gas emissions. We need to make our streets safer for all residents, regardless of where they live or how they travel.

*While both Measure EE and Measure FF aim to address street safety, I support **Measure FF** because it provides broader funding for safety improvements across the entire city, rather than focusing solely on bicycle boulevards and major pedestrian projects from the Pedestrian Plan. While still focusing the bulk of funding on street repairs and repaving overall, Measure FF will allow us to implement traffic-calming measures, safer crosswalks, and protected bike lanes across more of Berkeley, ensuring a more equitable distribution of safety enhancements. This citywide approach is crucial for making Berkeley safer for all modes of transportation while lowering transportation-related emissions.*

Additionally, we must prioritize high-traffic areas, school zones, and corridors with frequent accidents, using data-driven methods to determine where improvements are most urgently

needed. By investing in pedestrian and cyclist safety citywide, we can make Berkeley a safer, greener, and more accessible place for all residents.

7. Berkeley has a long history of using zoning, restrictive covenants and redlining to achieve racial and economic segregation. This history continues to shape Berkeley today.

Recent research by the Turner Center at UC Berkeley suggests that inclusionary zoning requirements, which mandate on-site restricted affordable housing in new developments, may have the effect of reducing overall housing construction, including the production of affordable units. However, on-site affordable housing can also be an effective tool for desegregating neighborhoods.

What is your perspective on how Berkeley should use inclusionary zoning requirements, versus other affordable housing development options (such as in-lieu fees)?

*Berkeley's history of racial and economic segregation, shaped by zoning, restrictive covenants, and redlining, still affects the city today. Inclusionary zoning, which mandates affordable units within new developments, can help address these inequities by integrating affordable housing directly into high-resource neighborhoods. I believe **inclusionary zoning is a crucial tool** for desegregating Berkeley, as it ensures affordable units are part of market-rate developments, promoting economic and racial diversity.*

*However, I understand concerns from the Turner Center's research that strict inclusionary zoning requirements may reduce overall housing construction. To address this, Berkeley should continue to pursue a balanced approach: maintaining strong inclusionary zoning requirements while allowing flexibility with **in-lieu fees**. Developers who cannot provide affordable units on-site can contribute to the Housing Trust Fund, dedicated to building affordable housing in transit-accessible, high-opportunity areas.*

The devil is certainly in the details here: How do we ensure that the in-lieu fees are appropriate to the size of each development, such that they still incentivize construction of affordable units on-site where feasible, without making construction costs too high and discouraging housing development overall? That's why I'm glad the Berkeley is closely studying this issue, and considering tweaks to the size and structure of in-lieu fees – as they did in a [May 21 worksession](#).

Overall, this hybrid approach ensures we do not stall housing production while continuing to generate affordable units. Berkeley's future depends on addressing past injustices, and inclusionary zoning, alongside flexible tools like in-lieu fees, can help us build a more integrated and equitable city.

8. Many of the highest income neighborhoods in Berkeley are also in the Hillside Overlay, portions of which are in the California Very High Fire Hazard Severity Zone (CalFire VHFHSZ). How should we balance fire risk with affirmatively furthering fair housing?

Balancing fire risk with the need to affirmatively further fair housing in Berkeley's hillside neighborhoods is critical. The Hillside Overlay, particularly areas in the Very High Fire Hazard Severity Zone (VHFHSZ), presents unique challenges for housing development due to safety concerns.

I believe we should not move forward with adding density in fire zones until we know that it is safe to do so. Safety should be our top priority – for current residents, as well as for the prospective new residents that would be added with greater density. But we also can't only use fire safety as an excuse; we have to address those safety concerns head on and make progress on them.

I do believe it's important to see the results of the pending evacuation study and heed the recommendations in that study to improve safety and better understand the threat. We also must move to increase public transportation, redstripe curbs on narrow streets, and reduce the number of cars parked on streets – to facilitate ingress and egress of people and emergency vehicles responding to a wildfire or earthquake. We must take every step possible to shore up our fire safety and prevention efforts. With that safety work proceeding, guided by the fire department and wildfire science, we can then evaluate where we stand and what might be a safe amount of gentle density that could be considered. Even without additional development, there are probably hundreds of existing in-law units and ADUs that could be brought into the market.

Beyond dealing with the fire risk in the Hills, we should certainly proceed with affirmatively furthering fair housing in high resource neighborhoods across Berkeley that aren't in fire zones. In itself that could help produce hundreds of units of new housing.